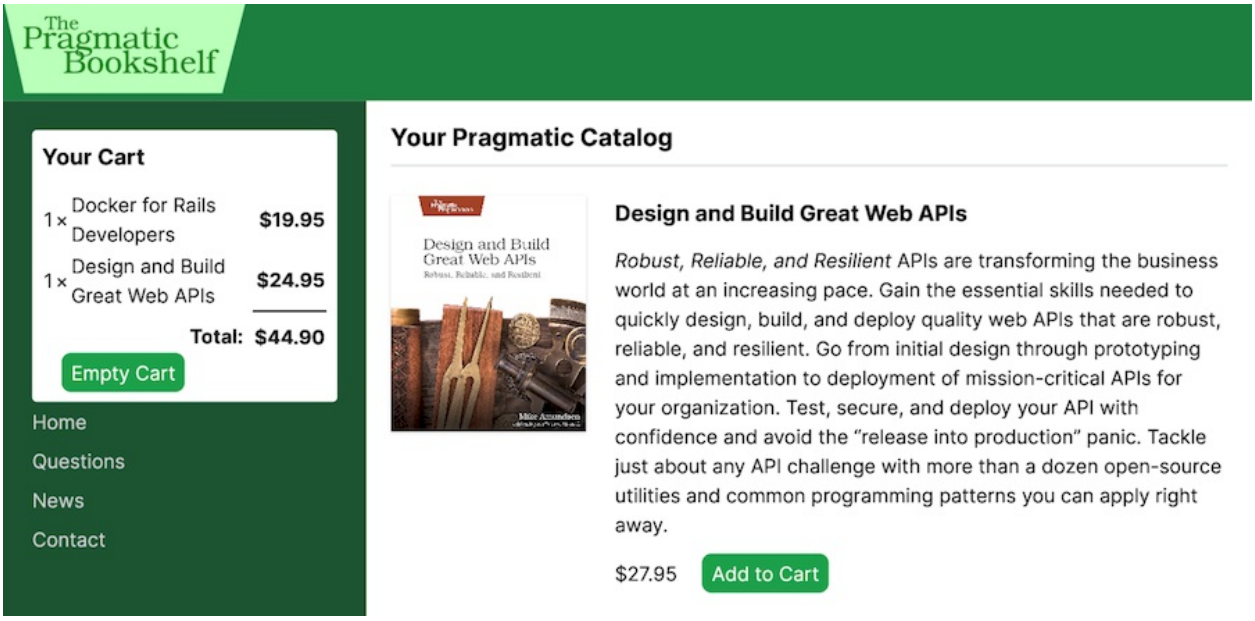
Iteration F4: Broadcasting Updates with Action Cable

Up until now, our users' web browsers have requested information from our Rails app, either by going directly to a URL or by clicking a link or button. It's also possible to send information from our Rails app to our users' browsers without a direct request. The technology that enables this is called WebSockets. [56] Prior to Rails 5, setting this up was fairly involved, but Rails 5 introduced Action Cable, which simplifies pushing data to all connected browsers.

We can use Action Cable and WebSockets to broadcast price updates to the users browsing the catalog. To see why we'd want to, bring up the Depot application in two browser windows or tabs. In the first window, display the catalog. Then, in the second window, update the price of an item. Return to the first window and add that item to the cart. At this point, the cart shows the updated price, but the catalog shows the original price, as illustrated in the following screenshot.



We discuss this with our customer. She agrees to honor the price at the time the item was placed in the cart, but she wants the catalog being displayed to be up-to-date. At this point, we've reached the limits of what Turbo Streams can do for us. So far, the server has only responded to requests and has no way to initiate an update.